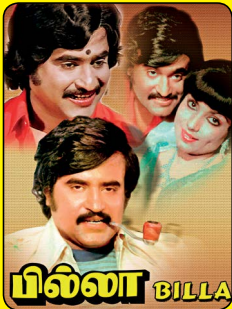
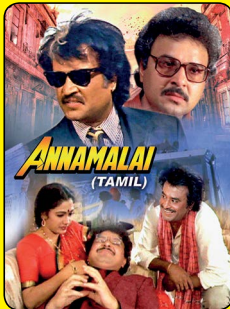


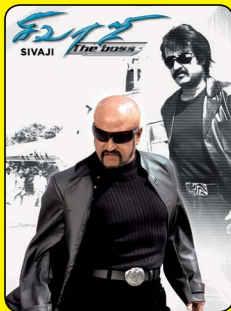
ROCKETING BRAND EQUITY



► **MOVIE BILLA (1980)**
PRODUCTION ₹50-60 LAKH
SALARY ₹7 LAKH
SALARY SHARE (%) 14%



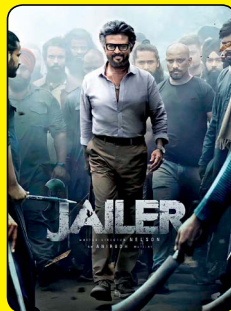
► **MOVIE ANNAMALAI (1992)**
PRODUCTION ₹5 CRORE
SALARY ₹1 CRORE
SALARY SHARE (%) 20%



► **MOVIE SIVAJI: THE BOSS (2007)**
PRODUCTION COST ₹60 CRORE
SALARY ₹20 CRORE
SALARY SHARE (%) 33%



► **MOVIE ANNAATTHE (2021)**
PRODUCTION ₹180 CR
SALARY ₹80-90 CRORE
SALARY SHARE (%) 50%



► **MOVIE JAILER (2023)**
PRODUCTION ₹200-220 CRORE
SALARY ₹110 CR
SALARY SHARE (%) 50%

► **Rajini's salary as a share of the film's production cost has risen steadily**

► **His fee as a proportion of production cost has risen to 50 per cent recently**

SOURCE: INDUSTRY ESTIMATES

WHAT MAKES RAJINI TICK

1

His on-screen charisma is built on unique styles and punchlines, man-on-the-street looks and down-to-earth real-life persona

2

His films pull crowds across age groups, including children. This translates into more business for everybody from the producer to distributor to exhibitor

3

He has a strong overseas market in the US, Russia, Malaysia and Singapore where there is a sizeable Tamil diaspora. Plus, a strong following in Japan

4

Finally, his brand is built on scarcity, where he doesn't appear in commercials or TV interviews. He can only be viewed on the big screen

BRAND FORMULA

A lot has changed in the intervening years—a much younger audience profile, the OTT (over-the-top content) revolution that has exposed viewers to content from across the world and made them weary of formulaic films, a life-altering pandemic that has changed cinema-viewing habits, the corporatisation of the film business and Rajini's own political non-starter that left fans disappointed. A lot many lapses within and outside cinema have been forgiven even before—the mega failure of *Baba* (2002), extended absences from the big screen, and a revelation that he was lending money at exorbitant rates. “Any other lesser star would have found himself in deep trouble,” says Pillai.

But not Rajini. Certainly not in the eyes of his loyal fan base that is ready to forgive his worst moves as they wait patiently for ‘Thalaivar’s’ next whistle-worthy moment on screen, even if it means sitting through duds. So, what helps ‘Brand Rajini’ dodge the several bullets that have come the actor’s way? Industry insiders often respond with “minimum guarantee” and “charisma”.

Everyone in the value chain earns at least a minimum profit with his films, say industry folks. Veteran producer-distributor-exhibitor Abirami Ramanathan, who has worked with Rajini in all three capacities, explains it thus: “Suppose a film of his is made for ₹150 crore, it will surely earn at least ₹200 crore at the box office. The producer is happy, the distributor is happy, and the theatre owners are happy.” As a producer, he is confident of recovering at least 1.5x the investment. As a distributor, the risk of losing money on a Rajini film is much lower, to the tune of 5 to 10 per cent. Ramanathan distributed many Rajini films in the Chennai territory till *Kochadaiiyaan*. For instance, he picked up the rights for *Sivaji: The Boss* (2007) for ₹6.75 crore—a big sum at the time—and made a profit on it, though he refuses to say how much.

For an exhibitor, Rajinikanth brings